

Class 10th Social Science

Power Sharing

Civics



Power-sharing



1072CH01

Overview

With this chapter, we resume the tour of democracy that we started last year. We noted last year that in a democracy all power does not rest with any one organ of the government. An intelligent sharing of power among legislature, executive and judiciary is very important to the design of a democracy. In this and the next two chapters, we carry this idea of power-sharing forward. We start with two stories from Belgium and Sri Lanka. Both these stories are about how democracies handle demands for power-sharing. The stories yield some general conclusions about the need for power-sharing in democracy. This allows us to discuss various forms of power-sharing that will be taken up in the following two chapters.

Chapter 1 Intro



I have a simple equation in mind. Sharing power = dividing power = weakening the country. Why do we start by talking of this?



Belgium and Sri Lanka

Belgium is a small country in Europe, smaller in area than the state of Haryana. It has borders with France, the Netherlands, Germany and Luxembourg. It has a population of a little over one crore, about half the population of Haryana. The **ETHNIC** composition of this small country is very complex. Of the country's total population, 59 per cent lives in the Flemish region and speaks Dutch language. Another 40 per cent people live in the Wallonia region and speak French. Remaining one per cent of the Belgians speak German. In the capital city Brussels, 80 per cent people speak French while 20 per cent are Dutch-speaking.

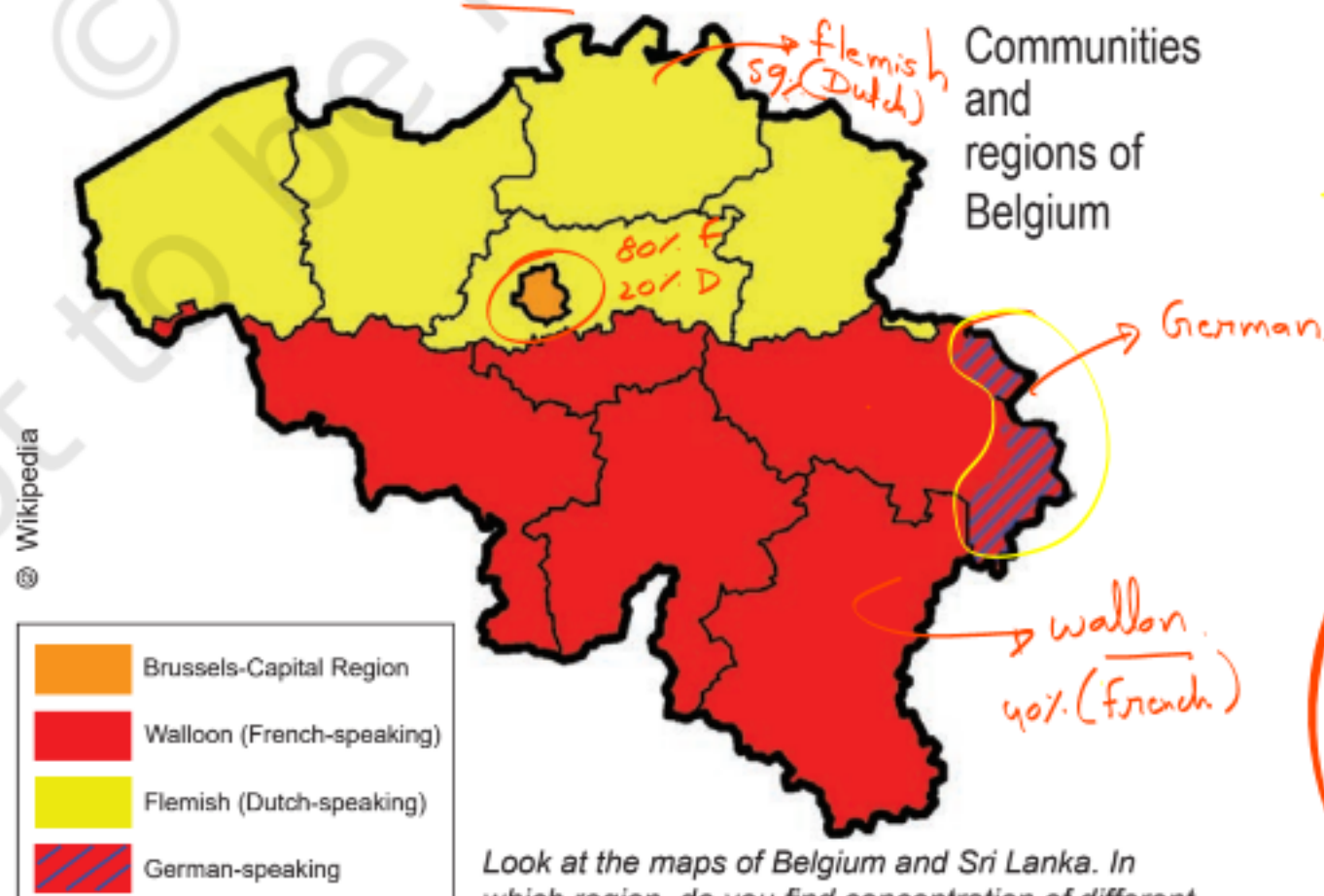
The minority French-speaking community was relatively rich and powerful. This was resented by the Dutch-speaking community who got the benefit of economic development and education much later. This led

to tensions between the Dutch-speaking and French-speaking communities during the 1950s and 1960s. The tension between the two communities was more acute in Brussels. Brussels presented a special problem: the Dutch-speaking people constituted a majority in the country, but a minority in the capital.

Let us compare this to the situation in another country. Sri Lanka is an island nation, just a few kilometres off the southern coast of Tamil Nadu. It has about two crore people, about the same as in Haryana. Like other nations in the South Asia region, Sri Lanka has a diverse population. The major social groups are the Sinhala-speakers (74 per cent) and the Tamil-speakers (18 per cent). Among Tamils there are two sub-groups. Tamil natives of the country are called 'Sri Lankan

Glossary

Ethnic: A social division based on shared culture. People belonging to the same ethnic group believe in their common descent because of similarities of physical type or of culture or both. They need not always have the same religion or nationality.



Look at the maps of Belgium and Sri Lanka. In which region, do you find concentration of different communities?

For more details, visit <https://www.belgium.be/en>

74% → Sinhala.

18% → Tamil.

Sri Lankan Tamils (13%) Indian Tamils (5%)

• S = Bu
• T → Hindu or Muslim
7% Christians

Ques 2 type of Questions Can be asked?

① Ethnic Composition of Belgium.

② " " " " of Sri Lanka.

Tamils' (13 per cent). The rest, whose forefathers came from India as plantation workers during colonial period, are called 'Indian Tamils'. As you can see from the map, Sri Lankan Tamils are concentrated in the north and east of the country. Most of the Sinhala-speaking people are Buddhists, while most of the Tamils are Hindus or Muslims. There are about 7 per cent Christians, who are both Tamil and Sinhala.

Just imagine what could happen in situations like this. In Belgium,

the Dutch community could take advantage of its numeric majority and force its will on the French and German-speaking population. This would push the conflict among communities further. This could lead to a very messy partition of the country; both the sides would claim control over Brussels. In Sri Lanka, the Sinhala community enjoyed an even bigger majority and could impose its will on the entire country. Now, let us look at what happened in both these countries.

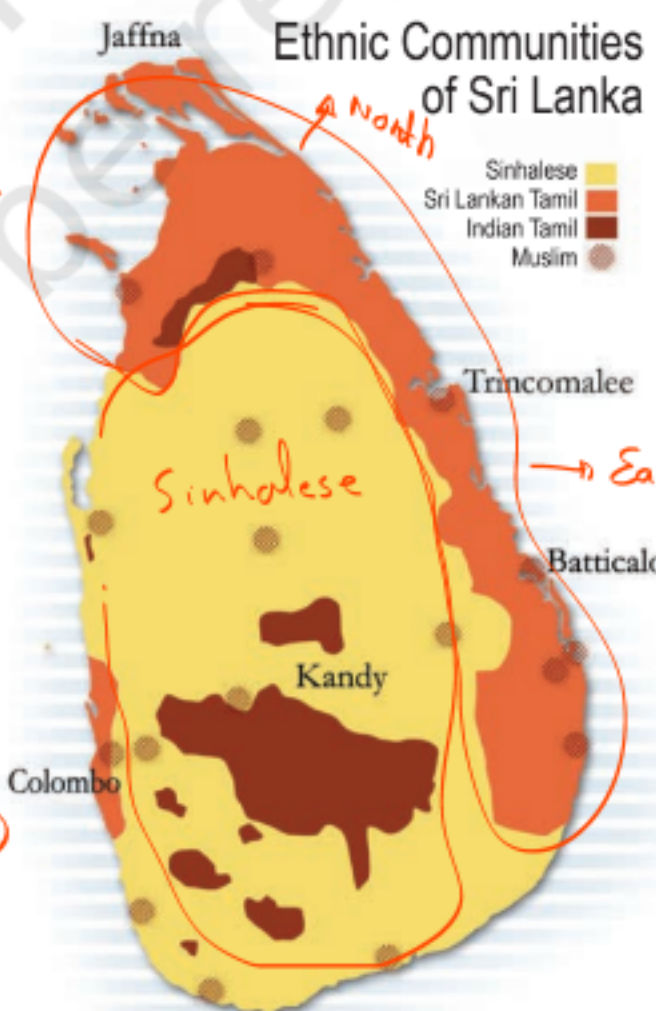
Majoritarianism in Sri Lanka

Sri Lanka emerged as an independent country in 1948. The leaders of the Sinhala community sought to secure dominance over government by virtue of their majority. As a result, the democratically elected government adopted a series of MAJORITARIAN measures to establish Sinhala supremacy.

① In 1956, an Act was passed to recognise Sinhala as the only official language, thus disregarding Tamil. ② The governments followed preferential policies that favoured Sinhala applicants for university positions and government jobs. A new constitution stipulated that the state shall protect and foster Buddhism.

All these government measures, coming one after the other, gradually increased the feeling of alienation among the Sri Lankan Tamils. They felt that none of the major political parties led by the Buddhist Sinhala leaders was sensitive to their

language and culture. They felt that the constitution and government policies denied them equal political rights, discriminated against them in getting jobs and other opportunities and ignored their interests. As a



For more details, visit <https://www.gov.lk>

Glossary

Majoritarianism: A belief that the majority community should be able to rule a country in whichever way it wants, by disregarding the wishes and needs of the minority.

How?

Practice Question for this Topic

CBSE Board Paper 2025 - Set [32/4/2]

Two statements are given below. They are Assertion (A) and Reason (R).
Read both the statements and choose the correct option :

Assertion (A) : The French speaking community was rich in comparison to Dutch speaking community in Belgium.

Reason (R) : Dutch speaking community got the benefit of economic development and education much later.

Options

- (a) Both, (A) and (R) are correct and (R) is the correct explanation of (A).
- (b) Both, (A) and (R) are correct but (R) is not the correct explanation of (A).
- (c) (A) is correct but (R) is incorrect.
- (d) (A) is incorrect but (R) is correct

Practice Question for this Topic

CBSE Board Paper 2026 - Set [32/3/2]

Identify the correct statement regarding Belgium.

- (A) Small country of Europe**
- (B) Big country of Asia**
- (C) Big country of North America**
- (D) Small country of Africa**

Practice Question for this Topic

CBSE Board Paper 2025 - Set [32/3/3]

Which of the following groups is in majority in Sri Lanka?

- (A) Tamil-speakers
- (B) Sinhala-speakers
- (C) Telugu-speakers
- (D) English-speakers

Practice Question for this Topic

CBSE Board Paper 2019 - Set [32/1/1]

Compare the situation of Belgium and Sri Lanka considering their location, size and cultural aspects.

Practice Question for this Topic

CBSE Board Paper 2026 - Set [32/4/2]

Read the given source carefully and answer the questions that follow:

Power Sharing

Power is shared among different organs of government, such as the legislature, executive and judiciary. Let us call this horizontal distribution of power because it allows different organs of government placed at the same level to exercise different powers. Such a separation ensures that none of the organs can exercise unlimited power. Each organ checks the others. This results in a balance of power among various institutions. Last year, we studied that in a democracy, even though ministers and government officials exercise power, they are responsible to the Parliament or State Assemblies. Similarly, although judges are appointed by the executive, they can check the functioning of executive or laws made by the legislatures. This arrangement is called a system of checks and balances.

- | | |
|--|---|
| 28.1 Explain the term 'Balance of Power'. | 1 |
| 28.2 Why is the judiciary considered independent in a democracy? | 1 |
| 28.3 How is power shared among different organs of government ? | 2 |

What's wrong if the majority community rules? If Sinhalas don't rule in Sri Lanka, where else will they rule?



Reaction and demand of Tamils

result, the relations between the Sinhala and Tamil communities strained over time.

The Sri Lankan Tamils launched parties and struggles for the recognition of Tamil as an official language, for regional autonomy and equality of opportunity in securing education and jobs. But their demand for more autonomy to provinces populated by the Tamils was repeatedly denied. By 1980s, several political organisations were formed demanding an independent

Tamil Eelam (state) in northern and eastern parts of Sri Lanka.

The distrust between the two communities turned into widespread conflict. It soon turned into a **CIVIL WAR**. As a result thousands of people of both the communities have been killed. Many families were forced to leave the country as refugees and many more lost their livelihoods. The civil war has caused a terrible setback to the social, cultural and economic life of the country. It ended in 2009.

Accommodation in Belgium

The Belgian leaders took a different path. They recognised the existence of regional differences and cultural diversities. Between 1970 and 1993, they amended their constitution four times so as to work out an arrangement that would enable everyone to live together within the same country. The arrangement they worked out is different from any other country and is very innovative. Here are some of the elements of the Belgian model:

- Constitution prescribes that the number of Dutch and French-speaking ministers shall be equal in the central government. Some special laws require

the support of majority of members from each linguistic group. Thus, no single community can make decisions unilaterally.

- Many powers of the Central Government have been given to State Governments of the two regions of the country. The State Governments are not subordinate to the Central Government.
- Brussels has a separate government in which both the communities have equal representation. The French-speaking people accepted equal representation in Brussels because the Dutch-speaking community has accepted equal representation in the

Glossary

Civil war: A violent conflict between opposing groups within a country that becomes so intense that it appears like a war.

What kind of a solution is this? I am glad our Constitution does not say which minister will come from which community.



The photograph here is of a street address in Belgium. You will notice that place names and directions in two languages – French and Dutch.